



Lammergeier

Gypaetus barbatus



An ancient Greek playwright, Aeschylus, was allegedly killed when an eagle dropped a tortoise, mistaking his bald head for a stone. Myth turned the eagle into a lammergeier: the enormous vulture that carries bones (and sometimes tortoises) and drops them onto rocks to break open, exposing the marrow or flesh. Lammergeiers can swallow and digest shards of broken bone and eat gristly, bony scraps that other vultures leave behind, although flesh and skin of live prey such as tortoises and hares are preferred. With their huge wings and

long tails, lammergeiers have a truly dramatic presence. This is often enhanced by a deep orange color brought about by iron oxide staining—they rub their feathers in red soil and rock dust and debris.

Highs and lows

Lammergeiers reach the summits of Africa's highest mountains and inhabit the most remote gorges, yet they frequently forage at town garbage dumps, where they are astonishingly agile at flying in congested spaces.

△ EASY GLIDING

A huge wingspan allows lammergeiers to glide almost endlessly with no effort. Occasionally they use a single, deep, emphatic wingbeat to adjust their course.

